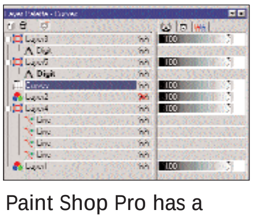
paint mode. Micrografx does have image layers but it functions quite differently when compared to Adobe Photoshop or any other image editing software. It works on the basis of objects, which means that various images can be added as objects on different layers and then arranged through buttons, but no blending modes are provided. One cannot hide them all—what one can do is send the image of one layer behind or in front of another layer, or merge all the layers to the base layer or the background layer.

In comparison to this, the functionality provided by **Adobe Photoshop** leaves one stunned. Not only does it have multiple layer support with blending and transparency options, but one can also move the layers manually. In this version of Photoshop, one can see distinctly the effects applied to the layers on the layers themselves. And one can hide effects by a simple click. Multiple options for locking of layers is also a first in this image editing software from the Adobe stable. Photoshop also provides various features such as accessing filters by right-clicking on a layer, which simplifies every user's work.

Paint Shop Pro provides almost the same functionality as Photoshop but the irritating auto-roll feature of the layer palette makes one wonder where the layers have disappeared. If you plan to use this, make sure that as soon as you open the software, you disable this option from the Preferences menu. The extremely small view of the layer palette will make one go bonkers if one were to work with, say, more than 20 layers. The developers need to pay more attention and improve this feature.



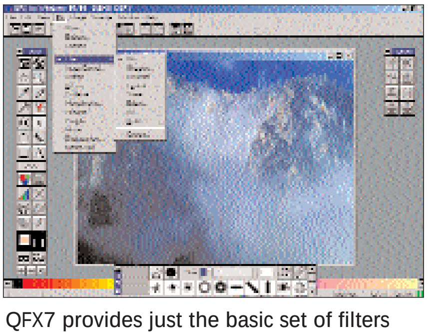
Paint Shop Pro has a very cramped layer style

Like Photoshop, Gimp provides the user with functions such as blending options, merging of various layers and increasing or decreasing the transparency.

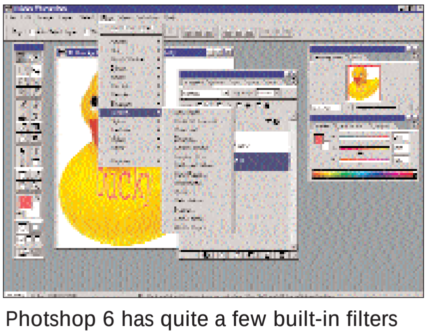
Filters: Ever wondered how the sky colour changes dramatically, or how a bright sun appears conspicuously in a dark picture? Well, the credit goes to filters! Jasc Paint Shop Pro boasts a set of 75 filters that let users create ripple effects or a lens flare and even remove scratches from a photograph.

QFX7 again fails to provide the user an extensive list of filters whereby he can create those jazzy effects. It provides the user with just a handful of basic filters such as glow, emboss, monochrome, etc.

Open **Photoshop** and your eyebrows start to rise as the huge set of filters drop down from the menu. From motion blur to lens flare and generating 3D effects, one can do it all with just this software, eliminating the need for buying and installing a different set of plugins. Hats off to the developers of this software for paying close attention to the needs of the professional user and seeing to it that only those set of filters are created which are actually used by them, and not bundle just any filters to compete with other software on the basis of numbers.



QFX7 provides just the basic set of filters



Photshop 6 has quite a few built-in filters and you can get more filters for free

Gimp, like Photoshop, also possesses a plethora of filters rendering various glass effects, motion blur, bump map as well as the widely used lightning effects. It offers the user a wider range of options.

Micrografx has a neat and a sizeable amount of filters such as image warping and red eye removal. It also has wizards to create some additional effects such as 3D puzzle piece, cool text, button maker, etc. In the filter menu, besides the general and texture effect, a host of other macro effects are provided.

Drawing tools: We all agree that it's pretty irritating to keep switching between two programs constantly. At times it becomes a problem when two professional programs are running simultaneously as there is a high chance of running out of system resources. Thus, it would be considered beneficial to the user if the image editing software provided some elementary tools to enable one to draw in the software itself.

Micrografx has a pencil tool which acts as a free form tool allowing one to draw the way one wants. Here, using the same tool, one can outline the size from the extra options seen in the toolbar. It also provides various blending options in the draw mode, which is strange because one would expect to have this feature in the image-editing mode.

Gimp, like Photoshop, provides the

Colour Modes

There are two popular types of colour modes: RGB and CMYK. The RGB mode consists of three colour channels (red, green and blue). This mode is called the 'additive colour mode' as the red, blue and green colours are mixed in different proportions and intensities to create white colour. This process can be more clearly understood by taking the example of one's monitor, which creates colour by emitting light through red, blue and green phosphors.

Although every person works in RGB mode when working with images, the final image is changed to CMYK mode when it goes for printing, which consists of four channels: cyan, magenta, yellow and black.

The first thing that one notices while converting an image from RGB to CMYK is the colour loss and the increase in file size. If that's the case then why do people convert images to CMYK? That's because to reproduce colour in print, you use inks in different proportions. Here cyan, magenta and yellow combine to absorb the entire colour and produce black. This is the reason why they are known as 'subtractive colours'.

Since all inks contain certain kinds of impurities, the first three colours combine to give a muddy colour which then has to be combined with black (K) to generate the true colour. Therefore, the digital artist will have to convert the image to CMYK before printing.